NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠10

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠10

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥J

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 4 ♥ A 7 4 ♦ K 10 7 4 ♣ A Q J 5	
♠ Q 9 8 2 ♥ 5 3 2 ♦ A 9 ♣ 8 7 6 4		♠ J 10 6 ♥ Q J 10 9 8 ♦ 8 6 3 ♣ K 2
	♠ A 7 5 3 ♥ K 6 ♦ Q J 5 2 ♣ 10 9 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

With no 4-card Major suit you respond 2♦ to partner's Stayman bid. Partner now bids 2NT.

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With 17 points you naturally accept partner's invitation and bid 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

East's ♥Q lead presents you with an immediate decision (or two) to make.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

You need 4 additional winners and can only establish 3 of them in ♦s. So you will have to manufacture another one from the ♣ suit as well. If you assume the ♣ finesse will fail, (and you have probably noticed that most finesses **DO** fail on these pages), that means you will lose the lead twice.

So what do you do about that ♥Q? Do you win or hold up?

You hold up, of course, to cut defensive communications when East has 5 ♥s and West has 3. East will probably play another ♥ to dummy's ♥K.

If both the ♦A and ♣K are in East's hand then you won't make this contract. He will easily establish his ♥s and have an entry to get in and cash them. If the ♦A is with East and the ♣K is with West then it doesn't matter in which order you play the suits since you will not lose the lead in ♣s. But if the ♣K is with East and the ♦A is with West then it is vital that you play ♣s first.

If you play on ♦s first, West will win the ♦A and play his last ♥, forcing out your ♥A. When East wins his ♣K he will cash 2 more ♥s.

But, if you finesse in ♣s first, East can win and establish the ♥ suit. But, when West wins the ♦A, he will have no ♥ to return.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q 6 2 ♥ Q 6 5 ♦ 10 9 3 ♣ J 7 5 4	
♠ A K 7 3 ♥ K J 8 2 ♦ A Q J ♣ 9 8	N W E S	♠ J 5 ♥ A 9 7 3 ♦ K 6 4 ♣ A K 6 2
	♠ 10 9 8 4 ♥ 10 4 ♦ 8 7 5 2 ♣ Q 10 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♥	Pass
4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠10

Did you consider bidding 6NT? You are balanced, and the points are right. But with two 4-card Majors you should use Stayman, so you bid 2♣. Partner bids 2♥. Now what do say next?

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You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least one Ace for his 1NT opening. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and while you don't like to use Blackwood when you have a worthless doubleton, this bid will at least keep you out of slam if partner has ZERO Aces. You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♥. Next?

Did you consider bidding 6NT? You are balanced, and the points are right. But with two 4-card Majors you should use Stayman, so you bid 2♣. Partner bids 2♥. Now what do say next?

You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least one Ace for his 1NT opening. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and while you don't like to use Blackwood when you have a worthless doubleton, this bid will at least keep you out of slam if partner has ZERO Aces. You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♥. Next?

He has two Aces so you bid 6♥ because you know there aren't enough points for seven.

The contract would be 6♥ played by West.

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♠10.

You toy with the idea of letting this ride to your ♠J, then you put away your childish toys and play the ♠A from dummy.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3

The two ♣ losers can be ruffed in dummy. A successful ♥ finesse could save you a loser in trumps. So, should you take the ♥ finesse now?

No, because if you play ♥A, then the ♥ finesse **LOSES**, North might play a third ♥ and stop you from your two ruffs in dummy. A much better plan is to play the ♥K, then ♥A, and if the ♥Q drops, well and good. This time she doesn't, but both North and South follow to both trump leads. Play the ♣ A K, the ♠K, and the ♦ A K Q.

If somebody ruffs any of these it will be with the master trump and you won't care. But if they don't ruff yet, you just start cross-ruffing ♣s and ♠s and let them ruff in whenever they like.

Missing 5 trumps to the Queen the correct play to avoid a loser is to finesse.

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 7 5 ♥ K 9 6 3 ♦ A K 8 ♣ Q 5 3	
♠ 10 8 2 ♥ A 5 2 ♦ Q J 10 6 4 ♣ 10 9	N W E S	♠ K Q J 9 6 3 ♥ 8 ♦ 9 3 ♣ A J 8 7
	♠ 4 ♥ Q J 10 7 4 ♦ 7 5 2 ♣ K 6 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♠	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♥
All Pass			

3♥ by South
Lead: ♠10

When the opponents overcall your 1NT opener a 2NT bid by partner is lebensohl. You have been instructed to make a relay bid of 3♣, and you do so. Partner now bids 3♥.

When the opponents overcall your 1NT opener a 2NT bid by partner is lebensohl. You have been instructed to make a relay bid of 3♣, and you do so. Partner now bids 3♥.

The 3♥ bid is a sign-off, ala the lebensohl methods. So you pass.

North would be playing the hand in 3♥.

South plays 3♥. West leads the ♠10. You win the first trick with dummy's ♠A.

You just have to pull trumps so none of your winners get ruffed. So play a ♥ at trick 2. West wins and plays another ♠ which you ruff.

Continue with two more rounds of trumps. Then play to a ♣ honor. Unless the ♣s split 3-3 you will lose two tricks in the suit but your fourth ♣ can be ruffed with dummy's last trump. Of course you also have the ♦ loser which you couldn't avoid.

A lot of hands are like this, nothing to the play and everybody who plays the contract will probably take the same tricks.

The purpose of the hand is to point out the advantages of using **lebensohl** convention when the opponents interfere. It got you to a makeable 3♥ contract.

And just look at the EW hands. They can easily make 3♠.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 6 3 ♥ J 10 9 8 ♦ 10 8 5 4 3 ♣ 8 6	
♠ 9 7 ♥ K 5 4 ♦ A Q 7 2 ♣ A K 5 2	N W E S	♠ K J 10 8 4 ♥ A 7 6 2 ♦ K ♣ 7 4 3
	♠ A Q 5 2 ♥ Q 3 ♦ J 9 6 ♣ Q J 10 9	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	3♠	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♥J

Partner bids Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 2♦. Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner bids Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 2♦. Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner's bidding is crystal clear. He has described a hand with at least 11 points, which has 4 ♥s and 5 ♠s.

The decision is yours, and with no 8-card Major suit fit you decide on 3NT.

West plays 3NT. On North's ♥J opening lead South plays the ♥Q.

On North's ♥J opening lead South plays the ♥Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

You must establish some ♠ tricks which means you will be finessing through North. Since North can get the lead at most once in ♠s you should not hold up in ♥s. The problem with a hold up is that South may pocket one ♥ trick and then switch to ♣s, a suit in which you are no better off.

Win the ♥K and play your ♠9, letting it ride. Suppose it holds the trick. Continue with another ♠, taken by South's ♠Q.

South cannot hurt you. If he has a ♥ to play, then ♥s will have broken no worse than 4-2 and you will lose two ♥s and two ♠s.

If South plays any other suit you have a double stopper and can establish ♠ tricks before they can set up a winner of their own.

Suppose you let South hold the ♥Q. That's one trick for the bad guys.

South could play a ♣, knocking out one of your ♣ A K. When South won his first ♠ he would establish the ♣s, and when he took the second ♠ he could cash 2 ♣ tricks.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ J 6 5 ♥ 7 6 4 ♦ A K J ♣ A K 6 3	
♠ Q 7 3 ♥ 10 ♦ 10 8 6 4 3 ♣ J 10 9 5	N W E S	♠ K 4 2 ♥ Q J 9 8 5 3 ♦ Q 7 2 ♣ Q
	♠ A 10 9 8 ♥ A K 2 ♦ 9 5 ♣ 8 7 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♥	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♥
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

Partner's 2NT is lebensohl, requesting that you bid 3♣. You obey and partner now bids 3♥.

Partner's 2NT is lebensohl, requesting that you bid 3♣. You obey and partner now bids 3♥.

The cue-bid is Stayman, asking if you have 4 ♠s. However, since it was a DELAYED cue-bid it also shows stopper(s) in the opponent's overcalled suit. Since you do not have 4 ♠s you go ahead and bid 3NT.

North plays 3NT.

East naturally attacks in his suit, leading the ♥Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

There are several possibilities for extra winners. The ♦Q might drop - or the finesse might work, providing one winner. The ♣s might split 3-2, giving you one extra winner. The ♠ honors might be split (or East might hold both) so the double finesse would give you two winners. Since your minor suit hopes require that BOTH of them work, your best bet is the double ♠ finesse.

You do not need to hold up on the ♥ because you will be finessing twice into West, and he cannot possibly have more than two ♥s, probably only one. Come to your hand with a ♣, play the ♠J and let it ride. West wins the ♠Q and plays another ♣. Win this one and finesse the ♠ again. When this finesse works you can return to your hand with a ♦ and repeat the finesse.

The double finesse has a 75% chance of success since it only requires that East hold either the ♠K, ♠Q, or both.

Even if West held both honors you would **STILL** have established one ♠ winner and would have the possibility of a ♦ finesse.